

JORVIK & Viking York - Grown-ups

UK Family Tour

Jorvik: The Viking Capital of England

The Great Heathen Army took York on the first of November, 866 — a date likely chosen because the Northumbrian elite was in church — and what followed matters more than the raid: nearly a century of Scandinavian rule in which Jorvik became one of the great trading cities of the North Atlantic world, second in Britain only to London, with a population estimated over ten thousand. The Coppergate finds document its reach: silk probably from Byzantium or beyond, a counterfeit dirham of Samarkand, Baltic amber, a Red Sea cowrie shell, Norwegian honestones and Rhineland lava querns — globalization, tenth-century edition. The Viking kings of York end with the era's best-named figure, Eric Bloodaxe, ex-king of Norway, expelled and killed in 954, after which the city fell to the English crown — but the Scandinavian imprint proved permanent: York's street names (the “-gate” suffix is Old Norse *gata*, street), a dialect substrate across the North, and the very name York, worn down from Jorvik. The deeper point the JORVIK Centre makes is a corrective: the horned-helmet raider of legend was, in York, a craftsman, merchant or farmer within a generation — cup-turners on Coppergate, moneyers striking coins for Viking kings who adopted Christianity with commercial pragmatism, sometimes stamping St Peter's name on one side of a coin and Thor's hammer on the other. Hedged bets, in silver.

The Horned Helmet That Never Was

The JORVIK galleries make a point of it, and it is worth dwelling on, because it is one of the most successful pieces of misinformation in popular history. Vikings did not wear horned helmets. There is no archaeological evidence for them, none, and there are good practical reasons why not. A horn or a wing on a helmet is a lever, an obliging handle for an enemy to grab, and a snag for every passing branch and blade. Warriors who fought for a living wore what worked, a plain domed iron cap, and the honest truth is that most Vikings, most of the time, probably wore no helmet at all, since iron was costly and a good helmet was a rich man's kit.

How thin is the evidence? Consider that in the entire Viking age, across all of Scandinavia and the lands the Vikings reached, archaeologists have recovered essentially one helmet complete enough to reconstruct, the Gjermundbu helmet, pieced together from fragments found on a Norwegian farm in nineteen forty-three. It is a rounded iron cap with a fearsome spectacle-like guard over the eyes and nose. No horns. That is very nearly the entire canon of near-complete Viking helmets. One.

So where did the horns come from? The theatre, and specifically the eighteen seventies. When Richard Wagner staged his epic four-opera Ring cycle at Bayreuth in eighteen seventy-six, his costume designer, a painter named Carl Emil Doepler, dressed the gods and heroes in horned and winged helmets to conjure a primitive, mythic, thunderously Germanic past. The look was a sensation. It spread from the opera house into paintings, book illustrations, advertising and, eventually, every cartoon and cereal box, until the horned Viking became one of the most instantly recognisable images on earth, and completely fictional. It is a rare case of being able to name almost exactly when and where a myth was born.

There is a teasing grain of truth underneath. Genuinely horned helmets do exist from Scandinavia, but

from the Bronze Age, more than a thousand years before the first Viking, and they were ceremonial religious objects, never war gear, the sort of thing worn by a priest in a ritual, of which only a couple survive. The Vikings themselves would have found them as ancient and strange as we find the Vikings.

Keep it in mind at the helmet displays here, and later before the genuine article across town in the Yorkshire Museum. Real Viking-age armour is plainer, cleverer and far more interesting than the pantomime version, which is rather the whole thesis of this museum.

Egil, Bloodaxe, and the Poem That Bought a Head

The base story leaves Eric Bloodaxe expelled and dead in nine fifty-four, the last Viking king of York, but he has a second life in literature that is worth carrying with you. Eric strides through the Icelandic sagas, written down two or three centuries later, and the greatest of them, Egil's Saga, sets one of its most famous scenes in Viking York itself.

The saga tells it like this. Egil Skallagrimsson, a towering, ugly, volcanically bad-tempered Icelandic warrior-poet, is shipwrecked on the coast of Northumbria and finds himself, of all the terrible luck, in the city ruled by Eric Bloodaxe, a man with every reason to want him dead. Egil had been feuding with Eric and his formidable queen, Gunnhild, for years, and had killed one of the king's sons. Gunnhild, in the saga a schemer and a sorceress, presses her husband to execute him on the spot.

Egil's friend Arinbjorn offers desperate advice. Compose a poem, he says, a great praise-poem for the king, overnight, and deliver it in the morning. So, the saga claims, Egil stayed up the whole night in Jorvik and produced a dazzling praise-poem of some twenty stanzas in Eric's honour, later known as the Hofudlausn, which means the head-ransom. He stood before the king and his warriors and performed it. And Eric, though he loathed the man, could not put to death someone who had just publicly glorified him without staining his own honour before his whole court. He let Egil walk out of York with his head still on his shoulders.

How much of this is true? The events are wrapped in legend, and scholars argue about whether the surviving poem is really Egil's and how much history sits behind the tale. But the scene captures something absolutely real about this world, the astonishing status of the skald, the court poet. In a society without newspapers, a poet could make or destroy a king's reputation, and reputation was the very currency of power. Verse was not decoration. It was propaganda, memory, insult and, on at least one legendary night in this city, a literal ransom for a man's life.

So Jorvik is not only a place of combs and cups and coprolites. It is a stage in the sagas, a city grand and dangerous enough that the greatest poet of the age gambled his life on a single night's work here. When you stand on Coppergate, you stand where the Norse imagination set one of its finest stories, the night a clever man out-talked an axe.

Coppergate: The Dig That Changed Urban Archaeology

The 1976 to 81 Coppergate excavation, directed by the York Archaeological Trust ahead of a shopping-center development, is one of the landmark digs of the twentieth century, and its significance was chemical before it was historical: the site's waterlogged, anoxic clays preserved organic material — structural timber, wattle, leather, textile, seeds, insects, parasite eggs — on a scale almost never seen in Britain. The team recovered around forty thousand objects and, more importantly, entire tenement plots: post-and-wattle then plank-built structures with walls surviving waist-high, property boundaries that remained stable for a millennium (the modern street preserves the Viking-age plot lines), and workshop floors identifying Coppergate's industries — wood-turning (the street name means street of the cup-makers), metalworking including coin dies, amber and antler working. The environmental archaeology was revolutionary: beetle and parasite assemblages reconstructed diet, hygiene and living conditions with unprecedented granularity — hence the celebrated Lloyds Bank coprolite, whose whipworm and maw-worm eggs quantify the era's intestinal reality. Public engagement was equally novel: the dig ran viewing platforms and drew enormous crowds, and when it closed, the Trust built JORVIK in the excavation's footprint in 1984, pioneering the ride-through reconstruction — smells included — that every subsequent "experience" museum has copied. Purists sniffed; five decades and millions of visitors later, the model looks like foresight. The glass floor over conserved deposits, and figures whose faces are forensic reconstructions from excavated skulls, keep the spectacle honestly tethered to evidence.

The Coppergate Helmet

Amid the forty thousand finds, one object stands slightly apart, because it predates the Vikings and because it is, quite simply, one of the finest early medieval helmets ever discovered. The Coppergate helmet, also called the York helmet, surfaced on the twelfth of May, nineteen eighty-two, in the least dignified way imaginable. The controlled excavation had moved on, a mechanical digger was clearing ground for the new development, and its bucket struck something solid at the bottom of a pit that had probably once been a well. The operator stopped. What emerged from the mud, once cleaned and conserved, was an eighth-century Anglo-Saxon helmet, made roughly a century before the Great Army ever reached York.

It is a superb piece of engineering and display. An iron cap with a nose guard and hinged iron cheek-pieces, it carries a curtain of mail to protect the neck, decorative brass eyebrows terminating in a small animal head, and, running from brow to nape and ear to ear, brass crest strips bearing a Latin inscription. That inscription is the extraordinary part. It is a Christian invocation, in the name of our Lord Jesus Christ and the Holy Spirit and God, and it ends by naming a man, Oshere. We do not know who Oshere was, but the name almost certainly identifies the helmet's owner, an Anglo-Saxon of high rank in eighth-century Northumbria, when York was a Christian centre of learning famous across Europe.

The rarity is hard to overstate. From the whole of Anglo-Saxon England, spanning some six hundred years, only a tiny number of helmets survive, and you can more or less list them, Sutton Hoo, Benty Grange, the Pioneer helmet from Wollaston, Shorwell, and this one from Coppergate, which is among the best preserved of them all. Each is a once-in-a-generation find. That York should yield one, by fluke, from the bucket of a digger, is the kind of luck archaeology occasionally throws up to remind everyone how much still lies unread beneath modern streets.

Why it was in the pit remains genuinely unresolved. It may have been deliberately concealed for safekeeping in troubled times and never retrieved, or deposited as some kind of offering. Whatever the reason, the same waterlogged, oxygen-starved ground that preserved the Viking city's leather and timber also cradled

this helmet for twelve centuries. It is not shown here, but a short walk away in the Yorkshire Museum, and it rewards the detour. Few objects connect you so directly, and by name, to a single individual standing in this place well over a thousand years ago.

The Workshops of Coppergate

The base story credits Coppergate with wood-turning, metalwork and amber. Stand for a moment on what the excavation actually revealed, tenement by tenement, because it amounts to a portrait of a working industrial street, and it is more sophisticated than the word Viking usually conjures.

The name declares the flagship trade. Coppergate is Old Norse for the street of the cup-makers, the koppari, and the ground was thick with the evidence, thousands of discarded lathe-cores, the waste plugs left when a bowl or cup is turned on a pole lathe. These were not amateurs whittling by the fire. This was serial production of turned wooden vessels, an entire block given over to it. Alongside worked the comb-makers, a specialised and often travelling craft, sawing and riveting red-deer antler into fine double-sided combs, since antler flexes where wood splits, and personal grooming was a genuine Viking preoccupation, remarked upon, with some disapproval, by English chroniclers.

Then the finer materials. Amber, fossil tree resin traded down from the Baltic, was worked here into beads and pendants, as was jet, the black fossil wood from the coast at Whitby, long prized for ornament and reputed to ward off harm. Non-ferrous metalworkers cast and finished brooches, strap-ends and pins in copper alloy, silver and lead, and, crucially, coin dies were found, placing the royal moneyers' operation in or near this street, striking the silver that powered the city. Ironsmiths, leatherworkers producing shoes and sheaths and belts, and bone-workers turning waste into skates, pins and gaming pieces round out the picture.

The subtlest evidence is textile. Jorvik's households spun and wove wool, and environmental sampling recovered the plants used to dye it, madder for reds and species yielding yellows, with evidence for woad blues, meaning the reconstructed grey-brown Viking of popular imagination is wrong twice over, once for the horns and once for the colours. These were people who liked, and could afford, bright cloth.

What makes all this remarkable is not any single luxury but the concentration and the continuity. The property boundaries laid out around the year nine hundred stayed fixed for generations, each narrow plot a house-and-workshop passing down a trade, fronting a street of shops. This is recognisably urban economic life, specialised, commercial and regulated, several centuries before the medieval guilds we usually credit with inventing it. The genius of Coppergate is that the mud preserved not the treasures of the elite but the machinery of an ordinary economy, the offcuts and failures and half-finished pieces that show us not what Jorvik owned, but what Jorvik did all day.

What the Vikings Left Behind — and a Trip Coda

JORVIK makes a fitting final stop because it inverts the trip's usual lens. The Tower, the palaces, the Minster — those are history as the powerful built it. Coppergate is history as everyone else left it: worn-out shoes resoled twice, a child's whetstone, bone ice skates for the frozen Ouse, lice combs (the Vikings were, by the standards of the age, notably well-groomed — English chroniclers grumbled that Danes bathed weekly and combed their hair, and won over local women accordingly), gaming pieces, and door-key after door-key, each implying a lock, a house, a household. The DNA legacy is measurable: studies of Yorkshire surnames and Y-chromosomes show substantial Norse ancestry across the old Danelaw, and everyday English still runs on the contact between Old English and Old Norse — egg, knife, window, husband, law, they — words so basic we forget they were imports. If the group has appetite left after the ride, the associated DIG attraction lets kids excavate replica trenches, and Viking-age York's other great artifact is free: walk Coppergate, Ousegate and Stonegate and you're following the tenth-century street plan itself. Then it's the 17:11 south — down the same corridor the Great Heathen Army marched up, at rather better speed — with two days of Viking mud, minster glass and city walls to argue about over dinner. As trip finales go, ending with the world's most famous coprolite has a certain honesty.

The Body of Evidence: Food, Dress, and Health

The environmental science at Coppergate did something monuments never can. It reconstructed the ordinary Viking body, what it ate, what it wore, and what ailed it, in forensic detail. As a coda to a fortnight of kings and cathedrals, it is worth ending at this human scale.

Diet first. Jorvik ate a coarse dark bread ground on rotary querns of imported Rhineland lava, and the stone shed grit into the flour, which is why Viking-age teeth are so distinctively worn flat, ground down over a lifetime of abrasive loaves. Around that staple came beef, pork and mutton, poultry and eggs, dairy turned to cheese and butter, and a steadily rising reliance on fish. From gardens and hedgerows came cabbages, leeks, onions, peas, beans, apples, sloes, plums and hazelnuts, sweetened only by honey. It was a calorie-dense, salty, seasonal diet, and by the standards of the age, in a prosperous trading town, a reasonably good one.

Dress next, and here the popular image fails twice. Not only were there no horns, there was no drab palette. Textile and dye-plant evidence shows wool coloured with madder reds, plant yellows and woad blues. Even the calendar remembers their habits, the Old Norse word for Saturday, still used across Scandinavia, means washing-day, the bath-day, a small linguistic fossil of a culture clean and colourful enough to keep both the comb-makers and the bath-house in business. The grey, matted Viking of the films is wrong about grime and hue alike.

And health, which is where honesty is owed. Life was short and hard. Skeletal populations from Viking York show heavy tooth wear and abscesses, joint disease and healed fractures from lives of physical labour, and the intestinal parasites made famous by the coprolite were effectively universal in a city with no sanitation, where people, animals and waste shared close, damp quarters. Childhood was dangerous, and many did not reach adulthood. The bones do not romanticise.

Put together, the picture is neither the horned barbarian nor the noble savage, but something more valuable, recognisable people, decently fed for their day, fond of colour and cleanliness, riddled with worms, worn down by grit and toil, trading with half the known world and dying young. That is the quiet achievement of this place. It reconstructs, from seeds and bones and parasite eggs, not an idea of the Vikings but the lived texture of individual lives, which is a far rarer thing for a museum to offer, and a fitting last image to carry south with you.

Silver, Coins, and the Making of a Market

One more layer for the road, and it is the layer that actually built Jorvik. Money. Behind the combs and the coprolite lay a sophisticated silver economy, and York was one of its great engines, home to a royal mint whose coin-dies turned up in the Coppergate dig itself.

The Viking kings of York grasped very quickly that coinage was both cash and propaganda. Their moneyers struck fine silver pennies, and the messages stamped on them are a masterclass in political hedging. Some coins of Viking York carry the name of Saint Peter, the city's patron, in Christian lettering, yet pair it with a sword, or with the hammer of Thor, pagan and Christian insurance on a single coin. Others carried a raven, the bird of Odin and of the battlefield. These were rulers converting to Christianity for hard commercial and diplomatic reasons while keeping the old gods in reserve, and they announced exactly that, in silver, in everyone's purse.

The wider economy ran on that silver by weight as much as by face value. Traders carried folding balances and sets of weights, many of which survive, and where a whole coin was too much they simply cut it, which is why hoards across the Viking world are full of hacksilver, chopped fragments of coin and ornament valued on the scales. A Samarkand dirham, a Frankish penny and a snapped-off brooch corner could all settle the same debt if the weights agreed. This is a monetary culture both primitive and startlingly cosmopolitan, indifferent to whose face was on the metal so long as the metal was good.

And it was governed. A working mint implies royal authority, agreed standards and enforcement, the machinery of a state guaranteeing and taxing its market. Combined with those stable property boundaries on Coppergate, the fixed street plan and the specialised workshops, the coins complete a picture that ought to retire any lingering sense of the Vikings as mere raiders. Tenth-century Jorvik was a governed commercial city with a money supply, an international reach and an administration, second in Britain only to London.

So as your train pulls south, carry this last correction. The men who took York in eight sixty-six with the Great Army are remembered for the axe, but what they actually built here was a market, minted and weighed and taxed, plugged into a trade network that ran from Dublin to Samarkand. The horns were never real. The silver, weighed to the last cut fragment, absolutely was.